

EYEWITNESS April 15, 1865

The Last Hours of Lincoln

At approximately 10 p.m. on April 14, 1865, John Wilkes Booth shot President Abraham Lincoln at Ford's Theatre in Washington, D.C. The bullet pierced Lincoln's skull above his left ear, causing a wound that was immediately recognized as fatal. Carried to a nearby boarding house, Lincoln would utter his last breath at 7:22 a.m. the next morning.

"The giant sufferer lay extended diagonally across the bed, which was not long enough for him ... A double guard was stationed at the door and on the sidewalk to repress the crowd, which was of course highly excited and anxious. The room was small and overcrowded ... I remained in the room until then without sitting or leaving it, when, there being a vacant chair which some one left at the foot of the bed, I occupied it for nearly two hours, listening to the heavy groans and witnessing the wasting life of the good and great man who was expiring before me. About 6 a.m. I experienced a feeling of faintness, and for the first time after entering the room a little past eleven I left it and the house and took a short walk in the open air. It was a dark and gloomy morning, and rain set in before I returned to the house some fifteen minutes later. Large groups of people were gathered every few rods [several yards], all anxious and solicitous. Some one or more from each group stepped forward as I passed to inquire into the condition of the President and to ask if there was no hope. Intense grief was on every countenance when I replied that the President could survive but a short time. The colored people especially—and there were at this time more of them, perhaps, than of whites—were overwhelmed with grief. A little before seven I went into the room where the dying President was rapidly drawing near the closing moments. His wife soon after made her last visit to him. The death struggle had begun ... The respiration of the President became suspended at intervals and at last entirely ceased at twenty-two minutes past seven."

GIDEON WELLES, U.S. SECRETARY OF THE NAVY 1861–69, FROM THE *DIARY OF GIDEON WELLES: SECRETARY OF THE NAVY UNDER LINCOLN AND JOHNSON*, 1911